

Heart Disease (Coronary Artery Disease)

What is Heart Disease?

Coronary artery disease (CAD) occurs when the arteries supplying blood to the heart become narrowed or blocked by plaque buildup (atherosclerosis).

It is the leading cause of death worldwide. Risk factors include high blood pressure, high cholesterol, diabetes, smoking, obesity, and family history.

Symptoms

Angina (chest pain or pressure) is the most common symptom, often triggered by physical activity or stress and relieved by rest.

Heart attack symptoms: crushing chest pain or pressure, pain radiating to left arm, jaw, back or neck, shortness of breath, cold sweat, nausea, lightheadedness.

Some people, especially women and diabetics, may have atypical symptoms like fatigue, indigestion, or jaw pain.

Medicines

Aspirin (75-100mg daily) prevents blood clots. Essential after a heart attack unless contraindicated.

Statins (atorvastatin, rosuvastatin) lower LDL cholesterol and reduce plaque buildup.

ACE inhibitors and ARBs protect heart muscle, especially after a heart attack.

Beta-blockers (metoprolol, carvedilol) reduce heart workload and prevent arrhythmias.

Nitroglycerin (sublingual tablet or spray) quickly relieves angina by dilating blood vessels.

Emergency Actions

HEART ATTACK EMERGENCY: Call 112/911 immediately. Do not drive yourself to hospital.

Give 300mg aspirin to chew (not swallow whole) if the patient is not allergic and is conscious.

Have the patient rest in a comfortable position (semi-sitting is best if breathing is difficult).

If trained, be ready to perform CPR if the patient loses consciousness and stops breathing.

Use an AED (automated defibrillator) if available and patient is in cardiac arrest.

What You Should Do

Follow a heart-healthy diet: rich in fruits, vegetables, whole grains, lean proteins; low in saturated fats, trans fats, and sodium.

Exercise 150 minutes per week at moderate intensity. Quit smoking — it is the single most important lifestyle change.

Take all heart medications as prescribed. Never skip doses, especially statins and aspirin.

Monitor and control blood pressure, cholesterol, and blood sugar.

Attend all cardiac follow-up appointments and get recommended tests (ECG, stress test, echocardiogram).